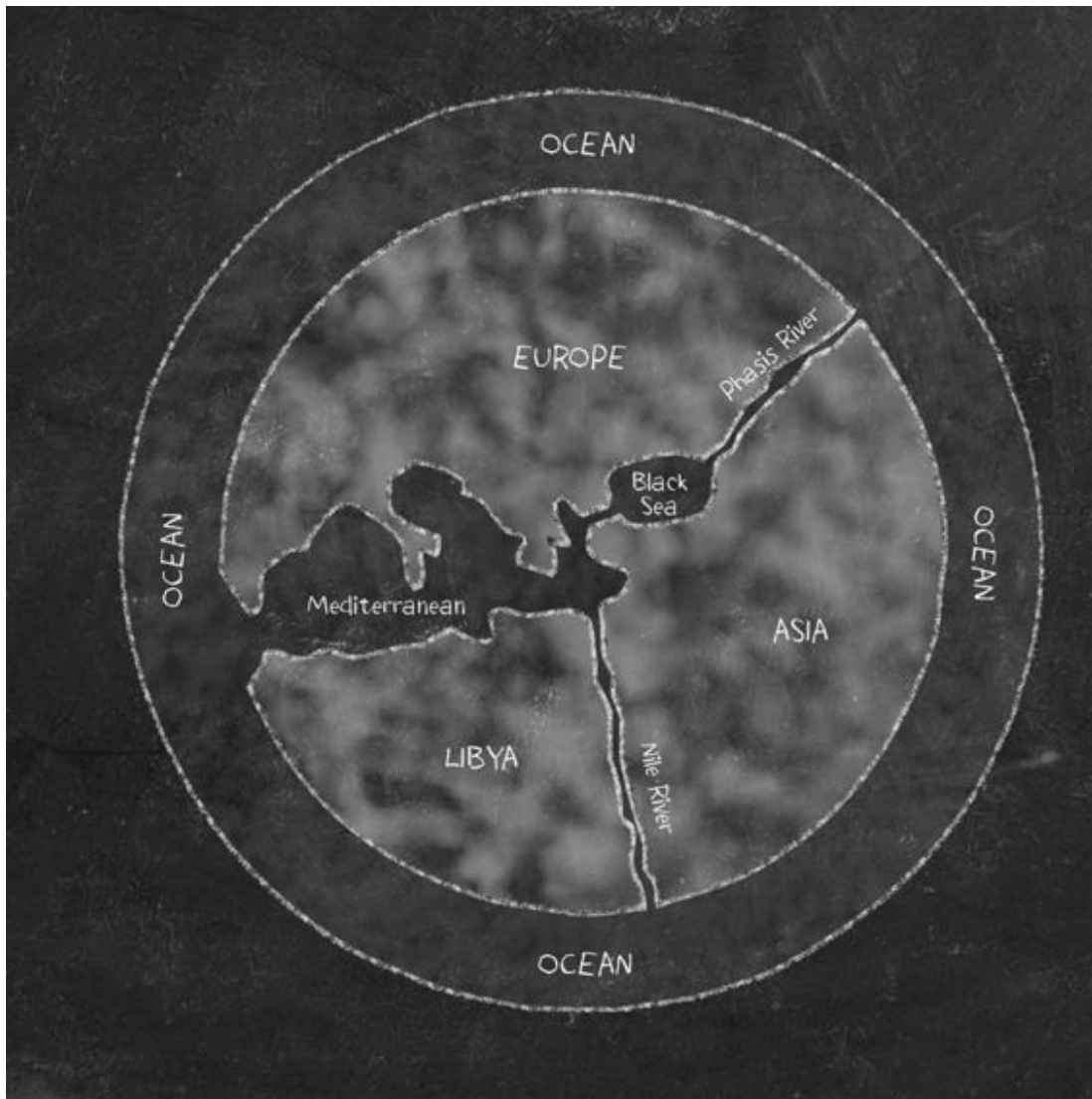


Anaximander and Anaximenes



One of the features of philosophy that distinguishes it from other ways of looking at the world is that its students are encouraged not to accept the conclusions of their teachers, but to discuss, argue and even disagree. This is exactly what happened in the very first school of philosophy, the Milesian school founded by Thales: his student Anaximander asked if the Earth was supported by water (as Thales argued – see [Thales of Miletus](#)), then what supported that? He suggested that the Earth was a drum-shaped cylinder hanging in space, with one of the flat surfaces forming the world we live on. Anaximander also had a pupil, Anaximenes, who said that the world

was self-evidently flat and floated on air. Using the same sort of arguments as Thales, he concluded that the single element from which everything is made is air. Although the conclusions of the Milesian philosophers seem to us hopelessly wrong in the light of later scientific discoveries, the process of reasoning used to reach them – especially argument and counter-argument – still forms the basis for philosophical investigation.